

	National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration	NOAA Administrative Order (OCAO Program Coordinator assigns numerical value.)	
	NOAA ADMINISTRATIVE ORDER SERIES	DATE OF ISSUANCE (updated to date of OHCS review, or later when signed) April 16, 2026	EFFECTIVE DATE (When NAO is signed) April 16, 2026
	SUBJECT NAO 216-128 Artificial Intelligence in NOAA		

SECTION 1. PURPOSE.

- .01 This NOAA Administrative Order (NAO) establishes the Department of Commerce (DOC) National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) Artificial Intelligence (AI) Policy. This policy provides high-level direction, guidelines, and governance to rapidly advance responsible AI use and development to advance mission and business objectives. Further guidance on how this policy is to be implemented will be provided in an AI Handbook that governs NOAA AI development and use.

SECTION 2. SCOPE.

- .01 This NAO applies to all NOAA AI development and use, including application development and use for business and administrative workflows, scientific research and writing, code development, and operations, and to the personnel and organizations that manage these applications, unless exempted by statutory or regulatory authority.
- .02 This NAO applies to all scientific software that contains, relies upon, is developed with, or enhances discovery using AI.
- .03 This NAO does not apply to AI to enhance simple administrative tasks as defined in the Handbook.

SECTION 3. DEFINITIONS.

- .01 AI-Ready Data: Data that is discoverable, machine-readable and machine-understandable, and has sufficient quality, documentation, and access methods to support the full AI application development and use life cycle.
- .02 Artificial Intelligence (AI): A machine-based system that can, for a given set of human-defined objectives, make predictions, recommendations or decisions influencing real or virtual environments. Artificial intelligence systems use machine and human-based inputs to: (A) perceive real and virtual environments; (B) abstract such

perceptions into models through analysis in an automated manner; and (C) use model inference to formulate options for information or action (15 U.S.C. § 9401).

SECTION 4. POLICY.

- .01 NOAA shall leverage AI to improve mission and business accuracy, effectiveness, timeliness, and efficiency, except to the extent limited by law, regulation, policy, contract, agreement, and security requirements.
- .02 NOAA shall maintain the NOAA Center for Artificial Intelligence (NCAI) consistent with Section 5303 (pp 1180) of the National AI Initiative Act of 2020—Division E of the 2021 National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA), and in alignment with current Executive Orders to advance the efficient and effective adoption of AI.
- .03 NOAA shall maintain a NOAA Artificial Intelligence Executive Committee (NAIEC) to lead AI approvals and risk management decisions with at least one representative from each Line Office and representatives from each Staff Office as appropriate.
- .04 NOAA shall ensure all AI systems used within NOAA adhere to scientific integrity and the ethical principles of transparency, fairness, accountability, trustworthiness and the protection of privacy and civil liberties.
- .05 NOAA shall undertake efforts to define, develop, and make publicly available data that is AI-ready to support efficient and trustworthy AI use.
- .06 NOAA shall create and maintain a risk management framework to govern use of AI for high risk use cases, safeguarding the operational integrity, safety, security and data provenance of these systems and their training data.
- .07 NOAA offices and programs using AI shall establish mechanisms for continuous monitoring and auditing to assess performance and accuracy.
- .08 This Administrative Order shall be reviewed periodically to incorporate advancements in AI technology, address emerging challenges, and ensure its continued relevance and effectiveness.

SECTION 5. RESPONSIBILITIES.

- .01 The NOAA AI Executive Committee (NAIEC) and NOAA Center for Artificial Intelligence (NCAI) shall be responsible for managing this Order in consultation with the appropriate NOAA Councils and Committees.
 - a. Detailed guidance for the implementation of this Order will be described in the accompanying Handbook that is aligned with Department of Commerce policies and directives. The Handbook will be developed and maintained by the NAIEC with implementation led by the NCAI. The NAIEC will review and update the Handbook at least every two years or more frequently as needed. The initial and

every two year review of the Handbook will be transmitted to the NOAA Executive Committee for comments.

.02 The NAIEC shall:

- a. Provide governance for, and delegate appropriate authorities to, the NCAI for strategic implementation of this Order;
- b. In coordination with the OCIO, establish and oversee the catalog of approved and not allowed broadly applicable AI-enabled productivity models, tools, and use cases in alignment with applicable laws, regulations, and policies;
- c. Establish a NOAA AI Risk Management Framework and serve as the AI Risk Management and Oversight Board;
- d. Establish data and metadata standards for AI-ready data in accordance with applicable NOAA policies and industry best practices;
- e. Assist NCAI in project tracking and policy enforcement;
- f. Establish and oversee NOAA AI Working Groups consisting of practitioners and representatives from across NOAA as appropriate
- g. The NAIEC Chair shall be responsible for communicating and coordinating with NOAA Leadership and DOC on the implementation of this policy.

.03 The NCAI shall:

- a. Coordinate and seek input and guidance from the NAIEC and appropriate Councils and Committees;
- b. Track and report on active NOAA AI projects to increase transparency, share tools, insights, lessons learned, and ensure compliance with standards;
- c. Act as a consulting body to NOAA Offices in the procurement process and use of AI capable software and services;
- d. Establish a community of practice for AI-enabled experimentation and application for NOAA employees and affiliates;
- e. Manage, and make available, AI training material and coordinate training opportunities for NOAA;
- f. Develop and maintain guidelines for assessing AI performance, accuracy, compliance and reporting for monitoring and auditing;
- g. Serve as a responsive entity for AI inquiries, providing coordination to ensure timely responses for NOAA;

- h. Monitor compliance with and reporting on this policy and the associated Handbook.
- .04 All NOAA Line, Staff, and Corporate Offices shall ensure compliance with this policy and the associated Handbook.

SECTION 7. REFERENCES.

- .01 Science and Technology AI Focus Area
- .02 NAO 202-735D-2: Scientific Integrity

SECTION 8. EFFECT ON OTHER ISSUANCES.

None

An electronic copy of this Order will be posted in accordance with Chapter 100 of the NOAA Records Control Schedule on the NOAA Office of the Chief Administrative Officer website under the Administrative Programs' NOAA Administrative Issuances Section.

<https://www.noaa.gov/organization/administration/noaa-administrative-orders>



Under Secretary of Commerce
for Oceans and Atmosphere

Offices of Primary Interest:

Office of the Chief Information Officer (OCIO)
Office of the Chief Administrative Officer (OCAO)
National Weather Service (NWS)
National Ocean Service (NOS)
National Marine Fisheries Service (NMFS)
Ocean and Atmospheric Research (OAR)
National Environmental Satellite, Data, and Information Service (NESDIS)
Office of Marine and Aviation Operations (OMAO)